



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

SUMMER'S ENCORE

An umbrella provides relief in Chinatown. Another heat wave is descending on the region. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

UC TAKES HARDEST LINE YET AGAINST DOJ SUIT

Judge is asked to reject ‘weaponizing’ of civil rights laws in UCLA antisemitism case.

By JAWED KALEEM

In the University of California’s strongest rebuke yet of the Trump administration’s pressure campaign against it, the university is asking a federal judge to throw out a Justice Department lawsuit accusing UCLA of enabling antisemitism, describing the case in court filings as “political coercion.”

UC is seeking to block a federal demand for repayment of more than \$2 billion in UCLA research grants going back to October 2023, when pro-Palestinian protests erupted on campus after the Hamas attack on Israel and the onset of Israel’s war in Gaza. UC said in court documents that federal authorities are more interested in bringing “institutions of higher education to heel” than in enforcing civil rights.

In a 539-page court filing submitted late Wednesday, UC’s lawyers asked U.S. District Judge Christina A. Snyder in Los Angeles to dismiss the case filed four months ago, alleging the government is “weaponizing” civil rights laws and has no legal basis for the suit.

The Justice Department sued in May under Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964. It alleged UCLA showed “deliberate indifference” to harassment of Jewish and Israeli students from October 2023 through January 2026. The law bars discrimination based on race, color or national origin in programs that receive federal money. The suit also claims UCLA violated its federal grant terms and asks for the funds to be repaid.

UC said in its filing that the federal demand covers more than 2,000 research projects, totaling a sum that far exceeds the \$1.2-billion fine sought by the administration in August 2025. That demand came after the government suspended \$584 million in UCLA grants over allegations of unaddressed antisemitism.

The Justice Department’s settlement proposal at the time sought sweeping changes to admissions, protest rules and other campus policies, including a public declaration that UCLA does not recognize transgender people’s gender identities. A federal judge blocked the fine and the proposal’s conditions in November after [See UC, A8]

Bill reckons with toxic legacy off SoCal coast

By ROSANNA XIA

Two members of Congress are ramping up efforts to investigate the consequences of DDT pollution off the Southern California coast — an issue that has horrified scientists and policymakers since they learned that as many as half a million barrels of toxic waste had been dumped into the ocean after World War II.

In a first-of-its kind bill introduced this week in both the Senate and the U.S. House of Representatives, the Ocean Protection and DDT Reduction Act lays out a long-awaited proposal on how to reckon with California’s poisoned marine environment. The legislation has been years in the making and seeks to address many of the concerns raised by Californians and others around the world.

“I was shocked ... I know firsthand how much our communities depend on a healthy ocean — from our fishermen and mar-

itime workers to our tourism and coastal economies. We have a responsibility to protect these waters,” said U.S. Rep. Salud Carbajal (D-Santa Barbara,) who introduced the bill with U.S. Sen. Alex Padilla (D-Calif.) and cited The Times’ coverage of the issue. “Our hope is to move things forward in a way that is meaningful, in a way that’s done expeditiously, and in a way where we are able to achieve a real, meaningful solution to this problem.”

Public concern has been mounting since The Times first reported the little-known history of ocean dumping off the Southern California coast — and how the nation’s largest manufacturer of DDT had for years disposed of its waste at sea.

Although DDT, which is short for dichlorodiphenyltrichloroethane, was banned more than 50 years ago in the wake of Rachel [See Waste, A7]

Bass and Raman court Latino voters

Candidates pitch to undecided Angelenos as election day looms

By NOAH GOLDBERG AND ITZEL LUNA



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COUNCILMEMBER Nithya Raman campaigns with Latino supporters at La Cita Bar in L.A. last month.

Voices **STEVE LOPEZ** COLUMNIST

Hoping the dream is still alive

The California I grew up in had its pluses and minuses, just like the state I’m living in now.

But consider this: In 1974, I wrote a check for a semester of college. The fee was \$98.

That was the cost of registration, by the way. Tuition for in-state residents was free at San José State University and other public universities in California. The state’s leaders believed subsidized higher education would serve the greater good and seed econ-

omic growth.

Two years after graduating, I was working as a sportswriter for a small Bay Area newspaper. My spouse was a drugstore clerk. Together we made less than \$20,000 a year.

And we bought a brand-new house, 45 minutes east of Oakland, for just under \$50,000.

In a thousand ways, we’re living in a different California today. Tuition and fees for a semester on a Cal State campus now run about \$4,500, and the average mid-tier home costs about \$775,000 in some

places and far more in others, which is out of reach for nearly 80% of working people.

So as I watched the gubernatorial debate Wednesday night between the two men who want to lead us into the future, I was wondering which California is better in terms of hope, opportunity and livability? The one I was born in during the postwar boom, or the one we’re living in now?

There’s no easy answer. The California of my youth was more affordable, but it was no utopian dream. [See Lopez, A6]

No votes gained or lost

Times columnists Gustavo Arellano, Anita Chabria and Mark Z. Barabak analyze Becerra-Hilton matchup. **A6**

Disagreeing on solutions

In their CNN debate, Hilton and Becerra share vastly different views on how to fix California’s problems. **B1**

ANALYSIS

Saudis looking beyond U.S. for security alliances

The push for regional pacts comes as Trump balks at helping fend off Houthi attacks.

By NABIH BULOS

BEIRUT — For decades, the relationship between Saudi Arabia and the U.S. has centered on an often-mentioned but rarely tested supposition: If the kingdom were attacked, America would come to its rescue.

But recent events have shown that much-vaunted security umbrella to be a leaky one.

Last month, Iran-aligned Yemeni rebels blitzed through Yemen’s coast and threatened to shut down Saudi Arabia’s Red Sea lifeline. But the Trump administration, reluctant to open a new front in its war with Iran, rebuffed Riyadh’s calls to come to its rescue.

That has left the kingdom searching for friends beyond Washington, for allies ready to put rockets where the rhetoric is and assist in a fight Saudi Arabia considers existential.

Over the last few months, as Persian Gulf nations contended with the fallout from the Israel-U.S. war on Iran, Saudi Arabia has supercharged its military-focused diplomacy. In July, it announced a 15-nation maritime alliance to safeguard shipping through the Red Sea, the Bab al Mandab strait and the Gulf of Aden.

Soon after came the Mecca Joint Defense Agreement, a NATO-inspired security pact under which any attack on Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan would be regarded as an attack against all three.

And this week, Saudi Arabia’s race to rally allies spurred a detente of sorts with its frenemy the United Arab Emirates, with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman — the country’s de facto ruler — and defense minister brother receiving the Emirates’ vice president for the first high-level meeting since the two sides fell out over Yemen late last year.

There have even been reports of possible cooperation between Saudi Arabia and Israel against [See Saudi Arabia, A3]



ANDREW CABALLERO-REYNOLDS AFP/Getty Images

CROWN PRINCE Mohammed bin Salman sought U.S. help. Above, he visits the White House in 2025.

Snake is fake; for police, a headache

AI image that sent Santa Ana into panic is part of new threat posed by such hoaxes.

By HANNAH FRY

The warning from police was so terrifying, it was easy to overlook it also was implausible.

A Gaboon viper — a highly venomous snake native to the rainforests and savannas of sub-Saharan Africa — was on the loose in a Santa Ana neighborhood.

Officials issued the alert Monday after a man shared with police an image appearing to show the dangerous reptile slithering from the thin branch of a tree onto the roof of a backyard shed.

The public got the message, with some parents keeping their children indoors while police and herpetologists scoured that backyard for the snake. The snake hunt was featured on TV newscasts and in newspaper articles. A woman living nearby called police in a panic after she found a snake, which turned out not to be a viper.

But almost from the beginning, some people questioned whether a Gaboon viper really could be slithering through the Orange County city.

After roughly two days of investigation, police informed the public the entire panic was driven by a hoax. The photo was a fabrication, generated by AI.

The sham thrust to the forefront a growing problem: [See AI hoax, A7]

Failed execution revives debate

Tennessee inmate is in critical condition, her lawyers say, as inquiry begins. **NATION, A5**

Defying Trump over drilling

Law aims to protect coast by slowing federal oil leases, boosting oversight. **CLIMATE, A9**

Growth forecast for California

Economy expected to continue to expand slowly, with meager job gains. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather

Hot with sunshine. L.A. Basin: 99/75. **B6**

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